

Survey Purpose

<https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSfiAJIhytrBv-sw9ePWaDY5xzZoEuWhYHQVf6WsYhXkUhlxUg/viewform?usp=header>

This survey aims to understand the limitations of current workout apps for individuals who want to continue training while managing injuries. The target respondents included both active fitness users and sports/rehabilitation professionals such as physical therapy students, sports medicine students, physical therapists, and coaches. The goal of this survey was to explore:

- Whether fitness users train while injured
- How current workout tools support injury-aware training
- What features users expect from injury-aware workout systems
- Professional perspectives on injury risk and safeguards in training tools

By combining responses from both regular users and professionals, the survey aimed to validate the need for an injury-aware workout adapter and identify gaps in current fitness tools.

By the end of the questionnaire, we received 26 responses in total, of which 19 respondents had experienced an injury before.

Survey Structure

The survey was structured into three main parts.

1. Screening & Demographics

This section collected background information to understand respondents' fitness habits and levels of expertise. Questions included:

- Age
- Gender
- Training frequency
- Role in fitness (general user, student athlete, PT student, athletic training student, sports medicine student, physical therapist, sports coach)

Based on the role question, respondents were routed into two paths: regular fitness users and fitness or rehabilitation professionals. This branching design allowed the survey to capture both user experience insights and expert perspectives.

2. Regular User Section

The regular user section focused on people who actively train. Key questions included:

1. Have you ever trained while injured or experiencing pain?
2. What workout apps or tools do you currently use?
3. Do these workout apps adjust workouts based on your injury?
4. Have you ever felt unsure whether a workout might worsen your injury?
5. When injured, which features are most important?
6. What is the biggest limitation of current workout apps when you're injured?

Key Insights

1. Training while injured is common.

Many respondents indicated they had continued exercising despite injury or pain. This suggests that stopping training entirely is often unrealistic for fitness enthusiasts. Instead, users need tools that help them adapt workouts safely rather than simply rest.

2. Most workout apps do not adapt to injury conditions.

Although users reported using common fitness tools (such as workout apps or trackers), many indicated that these apps do not meaningfully adjust exercises to account for injuries. Even when modifications exist, they are often generic and not personalized. This highlights a major gap between workout planning and injury management.

3. Users frequently feel uncertain about injury safety.

A large portion of respondents reported feeling unsure whether a workout could worsen their injury. This uncertainty suggests that users lack reliable guidance when modifying workouts during injury recovery. Current apps primarily focus on fitness performance rather than risk awareness or injury safety.

4. Desired features emphasize safety and adaptation.

The most valued features when training with injuries included:

- Exercise filtering (removing risky movements)
- Intensity adjustment
- Risk warnings
- Explanation of exercise modifications
- Long-term injury tracking

These responses indicate that users want decision support, not just exercise lists.

3. Professional Section

The professional section collected perspectives from individuals with training in sports medicine, rehabilitation, or coaching. Questions included:

1. Where do general workout apps fall short for injured individuals?
2. Can generic workout programs increase reinjury risk?
3. What safeguards should a workout app include before recommending exercises to injured clients?
4. Should workout apps distinguish between acute and recovery phases of injury?
5. What differentiates an injury-aware training app from a rehabilitation tool?

Key Insights

1. Generic workout programs may increase reinjury risk.

Professionals generally acknowledged that generic programs can lead to reinjury, especially when they do not account for:

- injury type
- injury severity
- recovery phase
- movement limitations

This reinforces the idea that one-size-fits-all training programs are unsafe for injured users.

2. Injury phase awareness is critical.

Experts emphasized the importance of distinguishing between:

- acute injury phase
- rehabilitation phase
- return-to-training phase

Most existing workout apps do not model these recovery stages, leading to inappropriate exercise recommendations.

3. Injury-aware training requires safeguards.

Professionals highlighted the need for safety mechanisms such as:

- movement filtering based on injury type
- Risk warnings for high-load exercises
- conservative progression

- clear explanations of modifications

This suggests that a responsible injury-aware workout system must function as a safety-aware training assistant, not just a program generator.

Key Takeaways

The survey results highlight several important gaps in existing workout tools.

Gap 1: Lack of Injury Personalization

Most workout apps do not meaningfully adapt training programs to users' injury conditions.

Gap 2: Safety Uncertainty

Users often feel unsure whether workouts are safe when injured, indicating a lack of guidance.

Gap 3: Generic Training Programs

Professionals warned that generic workout plans can increase reinjury risk if injury context is ignored.

Gap 4: Missing Recovery-Phase Awareness

Current apps rarely distinguish between injury phases, which is essential for safe training progression.

Product Opportunity

These findings suggest a clear opportunity for an injury-aware workout system that:

- filters exercises based on injury conditions
- adjusts intensity and training load
- provides risk warnings
- explains exercise modifications
- tracks injury recovery over time
- differentiates between injury phases

Such a system would bridge the gap between fitness training tools and rehabilitation guidance, helping users continue training safely while managing injuries.